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Franciscan sisters' school

UNICEF committee: Research Report

Establishing Separate Digital Spaces for Children and Adults to Prevent Child Sexual Exploitation Online.

Definitions:

Child exploitation: it occurs when an adult uses a child for financial gain, sexual gratification, labor or personal advantage, often during cruel or violent treatment that forces the child to participate in activities that can lead to physical and emotional harm potentially lasting into adulthood.

Digital Platforms: Business models that use online infrastructure to facilitate interactions between groups.

sexual abuse: when someone forces, pressures, or tricks another person into sexual behavior without their consent. It can happen to anyone and may involve unwanted touching, sexual messages, or other inappropriate behavior. It is never the victim's fault.

Luring: is when a person uses online communication to contact someone who's under 18 to make it easier for them to commit a sexual offense against that person.

Grooming: is building a relationship with a child in person or using the internet or other digital technologies to facilitate online or offline sexual contact with that person. A relationship is developed by using specific strategies such as complementing again, providing lots of attention and affection, kindness, gifts and money. Some grooming methods include love bombing (showering love) or gaslighting (using fear/shame).

Abusers: people who hurt, threaten, pressure, or take advantage of others, especially by forcing them to do something they do not want to do.

Minor: a person who is under the legal adult age, usually under 18 years old.

Persistence: is to keep asking for something, even when refused.

Sharing sexually explicit material: it includes sending unwanted sexually explicit material (pornography, nude photos, etc.) and trying to convince the victim that this kind of behavior is acceptable.

Introduction:

The Internet has become an important part of children's lives. They use it every day for education, communication, entertainment, and many other activities. However, being online also exposes children to different risks, including sexual exploitation and abuse. While child sexual exploitation existed before the Internet, digital technology has created new ways for this type of exploitation to happen and has made it easier for perpetrators to reach and communicate with children online.

As more children use digital platforms, keeping them safe online has become an important issue for governments, technology companies, families, and international organizations. This topic focuses on the idea of creating safer digital spaces for children and examining how these spaces could help reduce the risk of online sexual exploitation while still allowing children to benefit from the Internet.

Background:

In the late 20th century, the development of the internet changed the way people communicate, share information and interact with one another. As technology continued to develop social media, online games and messaging platforms became a major part of everyday life including children. At the same time however, these developments created new opportunities for Online Child Sexual Exploitation and Abuse (OCSEA), which has become a significant international human rights and public safety concern. Before the widespread use of the internet, child exploitation was generally viewed as a physical and largely localized crime, addressed through national legal frameworks such as the United Kingdom's Criminal Law Amendment Act of 1885 and the United States' Mann Act of 1910. During the 1990s, the growth of personal computers and public internet networks began to change this situation. Early online spaces, including Internet Relay Chat (IRC), and message boards, provided offenders with greater anonymity and allowed them to communicate across national borders. These spaces could also be used to share illegal material and establish contact with children.

As these new forms of offending emerged, governments began to recognize that existing laws and institutions were not always suited to the online environment. During the late 1990s, several countries therefore introduced new measures to address the problem. In 1996, the United States established the National Center for Missing & Exploited Children (NCMEC) CyberTipline, providing a central system through which suspected online child sexual abuse could be reported. The same period also saw the development of the Internet Watch Foundation (IWF) in the United Kingdom, which worked with the internet industry to identify and remove illegal content. At the European level, the European Union introduced the 1999 Safer Internet Action Plan, which supported initiatives such as internet hotlines, filtering technologies, and programmers aimed at improving digital literacy.

The nature of OCSEA continued to change as the internet moved beyond static websites and became more interactive. The growth of social media, mobile applications, online gaming, and encrypted communication gave offenders additional ways to approach and exploit children. OCSEA consequently came to include a wider range of activities, including online grooming, live-streamed abuse, the non-consensual sharing of sexual images, and sextortion. Because these offences could involve offenders, victims, and digital evidence located in different countries, national responses alone became increasingly difficult to apply. This contributed to greater international cooperation and the development of broader legal and policy frameworks.

International legal standards also developed during this period. In 2000, the United Nations adopted the Optional Protocol to the Convention on the Rights of the Child on the Sale of Children, Child Prostitution and Child Pornography. The Protocol required states that ratified it to take criminal and other legal measures against the production, distribution, and possession of child sexual abuse material (CSAM). The Council of Europe subsequently developed the Budapest Convention on Cybercrime in 2001, which provided a framework for international cooperation in relation to cybercrime and electronic evidence. This was followed by the 2007 Lanzarote Convention, which strengthened legal protections for children against sexual exploitation and abuse, including forms of abuse facilitated through technology. In 2014, the We PROTECT Global Alliance brought together governments, technology companies, and civil society organizations with the aim of improving international cooperation and strengthening responses to online child sexual exploitation.

More recently, governments have increasingly moved beyond traditional criminal justice responses and have placed greater responsibility on online platforms themselves. These approaches place obligations on online service providers to assess and address risks associated with harmful content and activities on their platforms. They may also involve measures such as automated detection, reporting systems, and the removal of illegal material. At the same time, these policies have raised difficult questions about how child protection can be strengthened without undermining privacy, freedom of expression, or the use of end-to-end encryption. The challenge for policymakers is not simply how to remove harmful content, but also how to develop effective protections that remain appropriate as online technologies continue to change.

Current situation:

Fast developments in communication technologies and social media platforms have enabled minors with opportunities for learning, communication, and entertainment.

However, the growth of these technologies has also given rise to new risks, including online harassment and sexual abuse.

With the spreading of smartphones and social media, communication between minors and adults has become easier, creating opportunities for abusers to exploit the trust that can develop through digital interactions.

UNICEF notes that while technology was not the cause of crimes involving child exploitation, it has given rise to new forms of abuse and exploitation and opened up new ways to reach and communicate with children.

In recent years, this phenomenon has increased alongside the continued use of digital platforms by children and teenagers, According to a recent UNICEF report from September 2026, at least 20 million children aged 12 to 17 across 21 countries, were subjected to at least one form of technology sexual exploitation ways or abuse in one single year, this represents approximately one in five children using the internet in the checked countries, The report also revealed that around 60% of these incidents happened on social media platforms, and that showed the importance of focusing on platform design in a way that limits opportunities for the exploitation of children.

So, separating adult accounts from minor accounts has been proposed as a measure that could help stop this phenomenon. This requires developing systems able to distinguish between adult and minor users, and imposing restrictions on communication between these two groups. Such measures could include limiting private messages sent by adults to minors, preventing certain forms of limited direct communication, and applying stricter privacy settings to minors accounts.

This policy does not aim to prevent minors from using social media or communicating with all adults, as digital communication can offer significant education and social benefits, but rather seeks to limit unsafe interactions with unknown adults who might exploit these platforms to access children. UNICEF emphasizes that while social media offers children substantial advantages, it at the same time creates new opportunities for abusers to reach and interact with them, making child protection a shared responsibility among governments, social media platforms, and society.

Some governments have begun adopting policies based on age verification as a means to develop child protection. For example, digital safety laws in the United Kingdom require certain services to employ effective methods for verifying user ages when necessary to safeguard children,

OFCOM explains that effective age verification is necessary for child protection, as it enables platforms to determine whether a user is a child or an adult, thereby allowing for the realization of appropriate safeguards without breaching upon the rights of adult users.

The European Union has also strengthened the protection of minors through the Digital Services Act. European guidelines regarding the protection of minors outline a range of measures that platforms can implement, privacy and safety conscious service design, and the limiting of risks such as child grooming, cyberbullying, and harmful content.

However, separating interactions between adults and minors presents several challenges. Establishing an accurate age verification system is difficult without collecting sensitive personal information or intervening in the user's privacy. Also, some minors may attempt to pass age verification systems, while abusers might use fake accounts or identities to gain access to children.

Therefore, relying on account separation may not be sufficient to eliminate online harassment.

Addressing the issue requires an approach that combines age verification, enhanced privacy settings for minors, fast reporting and response systems, platform oversight, digital awareness, and the enforcement of child protection laws. and, these measures must respect children's rights to privacy, education, and communication, rather than completely deny them from the digital environment. UNICEF makes sure that combating the online sexual exploitation of children requires cooperation among governments, organizations, civil society, and the private sector.

So, the issue of restricting communication between adults and minors on social media platforms has become part of a strategy to protect children from online harassment and exploitation, rather than serving as a standalone solution. As digital tools continue to evolve, there is an increasing need to protect minors while upholding their rights to internet access, learning, and communication. Achieving this requires international cooperation between governments and technology companies to build a safer digital society, one that shields children from exploitation while preserving the benefits of technology and respecting user rights.

treaties and organizations:

UN Convention on the Rights of the Child (CRC) – 1989

The CRC is a United Nations treaty that protects the rights of children under 18. It states that children should be protected from violence, abuse, and sexual exploitation, while also having rights to privacy and access to information. It is one of the main international agreements on children's rights.

Optional Protocol to the Convention on the Rights of the Child on the Sale of Children, Child Prostitution and Child Pornography (OPSC) – 2000

The OPSC adds to the CRC by focusing on the sale and sexual exploitation of children. It requires countries to criminalize these acts and take steps to prevent them. It also encourages countries to work together when dealing with these crimes.

General Comment No. 25 on Children's Rights in Relation to the Digital Environment – 2021

General Comment No. 25 explains how children's rights apply when they use the Internet and other digital technologies. It covers issues such as privacy, online violence and exploitation, access to information, and the role of governments and companies in keeping children safe online.

UN Convention against Cybercrime – 2024

The UN Convention against Cybercrime focuses on cooperation between countries in dealing with cybercrime. It includes offences involving the online sexual exploitation and abuse of children and covers issues such as investigating crimes and sharing electronic evidence between countries.

UNICEF – United Nations Children's Fund

UNICEF works to protect children and their rights around the world. In relation to online safety, it studies online child sexual exploitation and abuse and helps governments improve laws, policies, and child-protection systems.

International Telecommunication Union (ITU) – Child Online Protection (COP)

The ITU is a UN agency that works on information and communication technologies. Its Child Online Protection initiative focuses on making the digital environment safer for children and works with governments, companies, and other organizations on online child protection.

OFCOM – Office of Communications

UK's independent communications regulator, it oversees television, radio, telecommunications, and online services, OFCOM also enforces online safety regulations.
It plays an important role in protecting children online.

IWF-Internet Watch Foundation

Is a UK based, not for profit organization that works to find and remove child sexual abuse material online a UK-based, not-for-profit organization that works to find and remove child sexual abuse material online.

NCMEC-National Center for Missing & Exploited Children

Founded in 1984 by the United States Congress, it is a private, non-profit organization that serves as the primary resource in the U.S. for protecting minors

Questions to consider:

1. How can the international community establish common standards for separate digital spaces for children while protecting freedom of expression and privacy?
2. How can countries cooperate to prevent child sexual exploitation online when offenders and victims may be in different countries?
3. How can platforms make sure users are accessing age-appropriate spaces?
4. What role should technology companies play in preventing online child sexual exploitation?
5. What responsibilities should governments, parents, and schools have?

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